How it started

We founded Rooted Forward in Chicago after noticing how completely the city changes from one block to the next.

Looking for why, we learned how discriminatory urban development was carried out through practices like redlining, restrictive covenants, and urban renewal. We wanted to share that knowledge with others and drive policy change.

Students in other large American cities had seen the same patterns where they live, and joined us.

We are active in Chicago, New York, and Washington, DC.

Leadership team



Zain Zaidi
Chicago
University of Chicago Laboratory Schools



Ayomide Olatunji
Chicago
Harvard University



Sammar Agha
Dallas
Greenhill School



Osheanna Tyler-Hudson
Chicago
DePaul University



Sabina Aliyev
New York
Xaverian High School



Javonte White
Chicago
Collins Academy High School

Learn more about Rooted Forward

Take a tour or sign one of our petitions on our website, or write to us.

rooted-forward.org

contact@rooted-forward.org

We could use your help

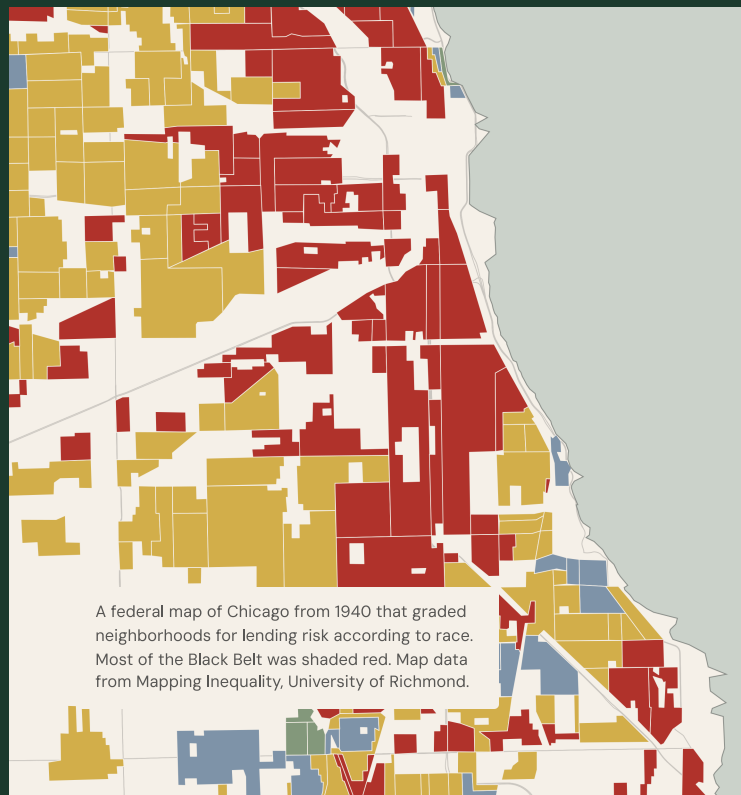
We want to partner with people and organizations who can help us bring this message to more people. If you or your organization would like our materials, we are happy to supply them.

We are also looking for people to help with archival research. You do not need experience to start.

Rooted Forward

Rooted Forward

A student-run nonprofit started in Chicago. Rooted Forward raises awareness of racial inequality in cities across the United States, and works to address it through education and political advocacy.



A federal map of Chicago from 1940 that graded neighborhoods for lending risk according to race. Most of the Black Belt was shaded red. Map data from Mapping Inequality, University of Richmond.

Ways we help



The plaza of the Obama Presidential Center on opening day, June 19, 2026. Photograph by AlphaBeta135, via Wikimedia Commons. CC0.

Scan for the virtual tour app

Free on iPhone

rooted-forward.org/tours



The map and its touch screen on the museum's wall in Bridgeport, September 2026. Photograph by Rooted Forward.

Community outreach

We do outreach and education in the community, showing people this history and our work and promoting our free tours. We have held events at farmers' markets and community events.

Self-guided walking tours

Our tours are free and run on our iPhone app. You walk a neighborhood at your own pace, and at each stop the app tells you what happened there. You can also take a tour from home.

Museum partnerships

We partner with museums, among them the Glessner House, the Japanese American Service Committee's Legacy Center, and the Chicago Maritime Museum.

Policy advocacy

We run petitions on bills that are already introduced and stuck in a committee, then submit the signatures as public comment.



The route of Walk Hyde Park, the first tour in the app.

School visits

We give presentations and lead workshops at schools, showing students our research and the history behind it.